

FABRIZIO OPPEDISANO INTRODUCTION The violent death of Valentinian III, one year after that of Aetius, constitutes an important turning point in the history of the Roman West¹. It marks the end of the late antique dynastic empire and confirms the crisis in relations between the monarchy and military commands. The immediate effect was a further hardening in relations with the *pars Orientis*² and a renewed aggressiveness of the Germanic populations settled in the Roman provinces³. The isolation and vulnerability of Rome, in turn, accentuated the climate of instability in internal relations that had already manifested itself in the age of Stilicho.

- 1 1. ¹ The break is emphasized by Marcellinus (chron. a. 454): Aetius, the great salvation of the Western Republic and the terror of King Attila, was slain in the palace by Emperor Valentinian with his friend Boethius, and with him the Western kingdom fell and has not been able to recover since. On this passage, cf. B. Croke, *The Chronicle of Marcellinus. A Translation With Commentary*, Leiden-Boston 1995, 93; M. Kruse, *The politics of Roman Memory. From the Fall of the Western Empire to the Age of Justinian*, Philadelphia 2019, esp. 172-180.
- 2 2. ² The signs of a crisis in relations between the two parts of the empire emerged when Attila asked Honoria for marriage (G. Zecchini, *Aezio: l'ultima difesa dell'Occidente romano*, Rome 1983, 264-266); they intensified in the following years, on the occasion of Marcian's appointment (V. Baini, *Per una nuova interpretazione del regno di Marciano*, *MediterrAnt*, 7 [2004], 373-405: 390-391). Marcian and Leo, on the other hand, do not seem to have played any role in the events of the *pars Occidentis* after 455, where all imperial appointments, up to 467, were the result of the evolution of internal relations; cf. esp. J. Szidat, *Usurpator tanti nominis. Kaiser und Usurpator in der Spätantike (337-476 AD)*, Stuttgart 2010, 125-130; 283-286; 347-356 and *passim*; cf. also F. Oppedisano, *L'impero d'Occidente negli anni di Maioriano*, Rome 2013, 61-62; 73-74; 105-118; see also *infra*, chap. III.
- 3 3. ³ For a general overview of the crisis in relations between Rome and the barbarians and the profound changes that mark diplomatic practices in this phase, A. Becker, *Les relations diplomatiques romano-barbares en Occident au Ve siècle. Acteurs, fonctions, modalités*, Paris 2013, 64-82. The most serious episode for the history of the Western Empire was the breaking of treaties with the Vandals, which led to the sack of 455, and which ultimately derives from Petronius Maximus's attempt to legitimize his position by breaking the marital promises, guaranteed by Valentinian III and Aetius, between Gaiseric's family and the Theodosian dynasty: U. Roberto, *Roma capta. Il Sacco della città dai Galli al Lanzichenecchi*, Rome-Bari 2012, 145-146. A worsening of the effects determined by the Vandal conquest of Africa is then recorded (on the periodizing value of that event, cf. e.g. C. Wickham, *Framing the Early Middle Ages. Europe and the Mediterranean, 400-800*, Oxford 2005, 87-93); in addition to the increasingly frequent incursions of the Vandals on the coasts of southern Italy and Sicily (*infra*, chap. X), starting from 455, according to Savino, the supply of the *res privata* to Rome ceased, with repercussions on urban demographics: E. Savino, *La conquista vandalica dell'Africa e la popolazione di Roma nel V sec. d.C.*, *Athenaeum*, 107 (2019), 156-168; cf. J. Linn, *The Roman Grain Supply, 442-455*, *JLA*, 5 (2012), 298-321. M.R. Salzman, *Emperors and Elites in Rome after the Vandal Sack of 455*, *AntTard*, 25 (2017), 243-263, discusses "resilience" phenomena after 455.

and which resulted in a retreat of imperial authority compared to the position of the *magister militum praesentalis* and the senatorial aristocracy⁴. In the twenty-one years between the death of Valentinian III and the deposition of Romulus Augustulus, the government of Rome passed from one emperor to another no less than nine times, with two long periods of interregnum (between 456-457, between the deposition of Avitus and the election of Majorian, and in 465-467, between the death of Libius Severus and the advent of Anthemius). The figure who, more than any other, was able to maintain a strong position for Ricimer, who remained at the helm of command for about sixteen years, until his natural death, which occurred in the summer of 4725. In this period of time, he outlived four emperors and, at least in three cases, was directly responsible for their death⁶. There is an impression of a military uprising, while the Roman emperor is not able to choose the military leaders of the *res publica*, a military *magister* of Germanic origin dictates the rhythm of successions to the throne. The image of an imperial authority now eroded by the commander's competition appears excessively ingrained in modern historiography, sometimes in an excessively schematic way: in an empire close to collapse, the last Roman principles have assumed the face of helpless puppets, moved in the shadows by their powerful general. There have been no specific clarifications, sometimes tending to blur or contrast this representation; this, however, has enjoyed a great fortune, which has favored a vision largely indistinct of the last Roman emperors of the West. Their profiles tend towards rarefaction and their personalities end up diluted in an amalgam of very subtle characteristics: weak, heterodox, incapable of acting effectively in society and of contrasting the forces that from abroad threatened integrity, these shadowy epigones of the imperial tradition now appear to reiterate the same failed experience, embodying in this way the agony of Rome⁷.

- 1 1. The transformation of the power relations between imperial government and senatorial aristocracy in the years following Theodosius, Milan 1990 (Rome 1942): F. Oppedisano, Santo Mazzarino and the late antique senate, *StudStor*, 61 (2020), 27-39.
- 2 2. On Ricimer, see F. Anders, *Flavius Ricimer. Power and Impotence of the Western Masters of the Army in the second half of the 5th Century*, Frankfurt a. M.-Berlin-Bern-Brussels-New York-Oxford 2010.
- 3 3. On the death of Avitus and Majorian: Oppedisano, *The Empire of the West*, 81-90; 273-278; on the death of Anthemius: Roberto, *Rome captive*, 178-193, on Libius Severus: S.I. Oost, D. N. Libius Severus *P. F. Aug.*, *CPh*, 65 (1970), 228-240.
- 4 4. In relation to the post-Theodosian West, the expression 'emperor-shadow' (*Schattenkaiser*) is used in an article dedicated to Odoacer to indicate specific figures, in particular Libius Severus, Glycerius and Romulus Augustulus: W. Menzen, *The History of the Germans*, 1, *The Time of the Pagan Ancient World until Karl the Great*, Zurich 1825, 157; F. Lorentz, *Occidental German Reich*, in *General Encyclopedia of Sciences and Arts, in Alphabetical Order*, by the aforementioned writer edited by J.S. Ersch and J.G. Gruber, with Copperplates and Charts, III, 1, published by M.H.E. Meier and L.F. Kämtz, Leipzig 1830, 243-260: 251 and 252; A. Wilhelm, *Odoacer*, *ibid*, 366-374: 368; L.M. Hartmann, *The Italian Kingdom*, Leipzig 1897, 43. The use of the word *fantôme* (phantom) is preceded: *Libio Severo* is defined 'the phantom of the emperor created by Ricimer' by J.-C. Royou, *History of the Lower Empire, since Constantine, up to the capture of Constantinople*, in 1453, I, Paris 1803, 524, while in the French edition of Gibbon's work, translated by M.F. Guizot in 1819, it is rendered with 'the reign of this phantom of an emperor', the expression 'nominal reign'.

Restoring distinctive traits to such figures is not easy, and in the most careful treatments of the concluding years of the Western Roman Empire, the need is often felt to associate an epithet with the names of the last emperors capable of distinguishing them from each other (Petronius Maximus is the noble, Avitus the Gallo-Roman, Majorian the military, Libius Severus the Lucanian, Anthemius the Greek), or to divide them by types (emperors of senatorial origin, military men, child emperors). The only experience of government that, with a certain frequency, has been recognized as having a different depth is that of Majorian. However, this has been valued predominantly for its eccentric character compared to the spirit of those years. Majorian seems to have interpreted his role as a tragic hero, stubbornly asserting the values of a Romanitas now tainted by barbarism, penetrating deep into the heart of imperial governance; he wanted to act more like a Germanicus or a Trajan than a fifth-century monarch, and for that reason, his attempt to revive the fortunes of Rome, however valiant, was destined inevitably to fail. In a vision that largely reflects the Justinianic perspective developed by Marcellinus and tends to assume teleological nuances, the impact of 476 becomes minimal: the deposition of Romulus Augustulus is the natural outcome of the collapse of imperial power that characterizes the years following the death of Valentinian III, and Ricimer's fortunate parable is the prefiguration of the subsequent one of the Scirian Odoacer. In the internal periodizations of late antiquity, the tendency thus emerges to group the two phases 455-476 and 476-493 into a single period of transition between the end of the Theodosians and the beginning of the Ostrogothic monarchy, during which, with the disintegration of the Roman political and institutional fabric, a new order is established, centered on the figure of a military leader of barbarian origin. Counter-tendencies, political experiments, or failed attempts tend to remain at the margins of an evolutionary process that leads, in all, linearly, from 455 to 476 and therefore to 493. (E. Gibbon, *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*, IV, ed. J.B. Bury, London 1898 [1788-1789], 25). In T. Hodgkin, *Theodoric the Goth. Barbarian Champion of Civilization*, New York-London 1897, 96-97, 'shadow-emperors' is now comprehensively associated with the period 455-476 ('with the single exception of Majorian'). It is an important passage, because during the 20th century these formulas gained widespread diffusion, especially in Anglophone historiography, both in the form of shadow emperors and puppet emperors. The entrenchment of such expressions is such that even in works attentive to the specificities of these emperors, they are used to comprehensively denote the last twenty years of the Western Roman Empire (see for example R.W. Mathisen, *De imperatoribus Romanis*. An Online Encyclopedia of Roman Emperors, <https://www.roman-emperors.org/libius.htm> [January 2020], where Libius Severus is «the fourth of the so-called 'shadow' or 'puppet' western emperors», or the recent contribution by M. McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors and the Choosers of Rome (455-476 AD)*, *AntTard*, 25 [2017], 95-112).

- 1 1. 8 See in particular D. Henning, *Periclitans res publica: Kaisertum und Eliten in der Krise des weströmischen Reiches 454/5-493 n. Chr.*, Stuttgart 1999.
- 2 2. 9 McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors*, whose classification appears arbitrary: if the senatorial profile of Petronius Maximus and Libius Severus, as well as Majorian's military profile, seem to effectively connote these emperors, it is not possible to affirm that Avitus and Anthemius were military men for the simple reason that they had assumed military offices.
- 3 3. 10 For the examination of these problems, see Oppedisano, *L'impero d'Occidente*, 9-14.
- 4 4. 11 See e.g. A. Demandt, *Die Spätantike. Römische Geschichte von Diocletian bis Justinian, 284-565 n. Chr.*, München 2007 (1989), 204-217; Henning, *Periclitans res publica*.

FABRIZIO OPPEDISANO Anthemius' experience does not escape this general vision, indeed it confirms it: his origins and the role played by Leo in his nomination have been interpreted as clear signs of Rome's weakness, but at the same time they constitute the causes of the civil war of 472, as if the Roman West was now spiralling into a condition that prevented it from one side from autonomously facing internal problems and external threats, and from the other side from accepting the command of a Graeculus and the interference of the Byzantine East ¹². An analytical study of the figure of Anthemius and his politics – which in this book is carried out systematically for the first time and from a plurality of viewpoints – allows for a different picture to be drawn, both of his role in Italy and of the power dynamics within the *res publica* in the final decades of the Western Roman Empire. His ascent to the throne was not imposed by Constantinople – which, incidentally, would not have been able to do so – but was the result of a convergence of interests: in the East, Leo got rid of an inconvenient figure, already invested in the succession by Marcian (whose daughter Anthemius had married), and could claim credit for having chosen the Augustus of Rome and restored the unity of the *partes*; in the West, the senate, after the failure of Majorian and the inertia of Ricimer, obtained the guarantee of a massive effort against the Vandals: it was precisely from Rome that the delegations moved with which the negotiations for the nomination began, which took place in the spring of 467 ¹³. The image of Ricimer's 'shadow government' is strongly re-evaluated by the examination of these events: if after the death of Majorian, in 461, he had conducted Rome's military policy with ample margins of autonomy and had been able to represent himself in ways that suggested an approximation of his figure to that of a monarch, his inability to effectively counter Genseric's threats eroded the trust of the senate: in 467, his main point of reference in the curia, the decemvir Basilius, was by then a close collaborator of Anthemius ¹⁴. The sixteen years in which Ricimer maintained his position as *magister militum praesentalis* thus escape a homogeneous framework: his aspiration to act beyond the perimeter of the functions strictly connected to his office ¹⁵ reached its maximum realization between Majorian and Anthemius. Earlier, in 457, his attempt to assume a leading role in the new imperial government had been frustrated by Majorian's choices, just as later, in 466/467, his ambitions would have been forced to recede in the face of the senate's new orientations. In both cases, external events allowed him to regain ground: the destruction of Majorian's fleet and the failure of Anthemius' military project. It can be affirmed that, at least in these two circumstances, Ricimer's momentary success was favored by Genseric's political stature.

1 1. ¹² On this aspect, see below, chap. I.

2 2. ¹³ Below, chap. IV.

3 3. ¹⁴ Ibid.

4 4. ¹⁵ On the problems related to the powers of the *magister militum praesentalis*, see below, chap. IX (with references to historiographical orientations).

INTRODUCTION The defeat inflicted on the Roman forces by the Vandal king constitutes the main cause of the end of the government of Anthemius (as already happened in the case of Majorian). The Eastern origins, however, had no weight in the outcome of his political parable: in a particularly complex cultural and religious context, Anthemius's hinterland, above all, aroused suspicion in Rome. Certainly, the role assumed by the Eastern court could arouse the fear of a progressive extension of its authority in the West, but this was the price that the Italian classes were willing to pay in exchange for the commitment to strengthen the Roman military presence in the central Mediterranean. Anthemius's origin is the spy of an ambitious experiment, and the *concordia tra le due partes imperii*, found after a period of cold relations, is an expression of the vitality of a world that experienced new strategies to counteract the insidious and multiple problems that threatened Rome's integrity. The year 455 was also a moment of rupture that gave life to a creative phase in the history of the Western Roman Empire. With the death of Aetius and the end of the Theodosian dynasty, the fragility of the imperial government was aggravated, which, however, did not originate at the time, but descended from the crisis of the Stilicho era. At that moment, the senatorial aristocracy – which in determining that crisis had shown evident responsibilities – acted to find a remedy: it did so in a disorganized way, now supporting Ricimer, now favoring – in particular with Majorian and Anthemius – projects that aimed to restore stability to the Roman empire through the restitution to Rome of territories lost in Africa and Gaul, and through the centralization, under the direct authority of the Roman emperor, of government functions, both civil and military. *** The choice of themes on which the ten chapters of this volume are based is the intention to consolidate the analysis of Anthemius's figure into a broader reasoning about the Western Roman Empire. In the first part, Between East and West, three chapters are dedicated to the overall problem of the perception of the Greeks in the West, to the origins of Anthemius, to political relations between the two parts of the empire; in the second, Anthemius in Rome, to the settlement of Anthemius and the organization of the imperial monogram are studied in close connection with the cultural and religious context of the city of Rome; in the third, International politics and military politics, the political directions that emerge from the legislation, the military structure and the strategies put in place in those years are finally analyzed. The book is part of a broader project, by me conducted at the Scuola Normale Superiore from 2017, which provides for the parallel publication of a monograph on Anthemius's panegyric. The two works are complementary. I am grateful to the Scuola Normale for having entirely financed the project, to the anonymous reviewers who have read this book, and to the authors who have contributed to its realization.

1 1. *Infra*, chaps. V and VI.